FedRAS: Network-Conditioned Rank Allocation for Federated LoRA

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Abstract

Federated LoRA reduces update size, but a fixed rank cannot adapt to time-varying links. We formulate rank selection and client admission as a joint network scheduling problem and call the resulting method FedRAS. It estimates a delivery probability and an adaptation capacity for each client–rank pair, maximizes the expected useful updates under byte-budget and participation constraints, solves the assignment with a dynamic program, and aggregates heterogeneous ranks with frozen-factor rank masking. All payloads are accounted at their real serialized sizes: a frozen-A client uploads only the trainable B factor, a small fraction of a full-model update.

Experiments on non-IID CIFAR-10, CIFAR-100, and MNIST, with a 500-client scheduler simulation, use deadlines recalibrated to the real payloads. At the nominal deadline, rank selection reduces to fixed rank-16 behavior at zero cost. Under deadline stress, FedRAS delivers 22% more timely updates and 23% fewer bytes than fixed rank 16 at statistically equivalent accuracy, while full-parameter updates miss every stress deadline. The exact scheduler beats greedy heuristics whenever the byte budget binds, at sub-second per-round cost, and miscalibrated delivery predictions degrade the assignment objective by at most 1%.

Keywords: Federated LoRA, Mobile edge computing, Rank selection, Deadline scheduling, Wireless federated learning

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1. Introduction

Mobile edge networks increasingly host federated learning (FL) workloads in which heterogeneous clients such as smartphones, vehicles, UAV terminals, and satellite-connected devices collaborate on a shared model without exposing raw data [1, 2, 3, 4]. The dominant cost in such systems is the uplink. Full-parameter model updates saturate wireless capacity, drain client energy, and frequently miss round deadlines when links degrade during handover or outage, as reported for ground, aerial, and satellite segments [5, 6, 7, 8]. Low-rank adaptation (LoRA) has therefore become an attractive transmission format for FL, because only two small factor matrices per adapted layer are communicated instead of the full weight delta [9, 10, 11].

Existing Federated LoRA systems, however, treat the rank r as a model hyperparameter. The rank is selected from data and system constraints alone, possibly varying across clients [12, 13] or adapting across rounds [14, 15], but not from the state of a lossy, deadline-constrained link. This convention ignores a scheduling dimension that is directly visible to the network. The omitted coupling is mechanical. A larger rank transmits more bytes and therefore loses delivery probability exactly where it gains adaptation capacity, while a smaller rank travels light but forfeits capacity on the healthy links that could have carried it. Whether the extra capacity is worth the delivery risk depends on the link state, and no training-side rule observes that state.

This raises three questions. How should delivery probability depend on rank and observable link state? How should client–rank assignment be solved under budget and participation constraints? Does the resulting adaptation improve network behavior in a real trainer? These questions are answered in Sections 3, 4, and 6, respectively.

We answer these questions with a delivery model, a grid-based dynamic-programming solver, a rank-selection rule, and a two-tier evaluation. We call the method FedRAS. The contributions are as follows.

- **Deadline-aware client–rank model.** We formulate each round as a joint assignment in which admission and rank are selected together. The model links rank to its real serialized payload, a delivery probability $P_{\mathrm{on}}(r)$, and a saturating capacity gain $G(r)$. Section 3 develops the model and the scheduling formulation.

- **Dynamic-programming scheduler.** The estimated problem is a multiple-choice knapsack with an admission cap. We derive a pseudo-polynomial dynamic program that is exact for the discretized single-round estimated assignment problem, with complexity $O(|\mathcal{D}|KB_{\max}|\mathcal{R}|)$. The solver study measures greedy gaps and runtime.

- **Heterogeneous-rank aggregation.** We use rank-masked averaging with a shared frozen A factor, so only the trainable B factor is ever uploaded. Under this condition, the rule gives exact coordinate-wise averaging of active induced-update slices. Proposition 3 states the conditions and limits.

- **Two-tier evaluation at real payload sizes.** A real trainer covers non-IID CIFAR-10, CIFAR-100, and MNIST, and a 500-client scheduler simulation covers deadline, budget, mobility, and scale regimes. Under deadline stress, FedRAS delivers more timely updates with fewer bytes than fixed-rank operation at equivalent accuracy, while full-parameter updates miss every stress deadline. The evaluation further covers external baselines, a candidate-pool decomposition of the scheduler's gains, a SAGIN link profile, and pre-registered equivalence tests.

We report accuracy, timely delivery ratio, and bytes per round as separate outcomes.

A preliminary poster version of this work studied joint client–protection scheduling for federated learning in space–air–ground mobile networks [16]. The present article substantially reformulates that line of work around a different schedulable resource. It replaces compression-and-protection policies with the LoRA rank as the per-client decision variable. It introduces the real-payload delivery hazard and the saturating capacity model of Section 3, replaces the heuristic admission-and-repair procedure with a dynamic program that is exact on the stated budget grid, and adds frozen-factor rank-masked aggregation for heterogeneous ranks. It also reports a new two-tier evaluation comprising a real federated LoRA trainer, a 500-client scheduling simulator, and a solver exactness study. Accordingly, all numerical results in this article come from the revised formulation and implementation and are not comparable with the preliminary version.

The remainder of this paper is organized as follows. Section 2 reviews related work. Section 3 presents the system model, the adversary and trust

assumptions, and the scheduling formulation. Section 4 describes the FedRAS design and Section 5 its theoretical analysis. Section 6 reports the experimental evaluation, Section 7 discusses interpretation, deployment, and limitations, and Section 8 concludes.

2. Related work

2.1. Federated LoRA and heterogeneous-rank adaptation

LoRA freezes a pretrained backbone and learns low-rank increments $\Delta W = BA$ [9]. Federated LoRA trains these adapters across clients. Prior work has studied sparse updates and instruction tuning [10, 11], examined how standard parameter-efficient tuning behaves under the federated setting [17], and pursued personalization through model-heterogeneous or dual-adapter designs [18, 19]. A further line lets the rank vary across clients and aligns heterogeneous ranks for aggregation, by rank self-pruning with sparsity-weighted averaging [12], stacking [20], zero-padded rank alignment [13], or SVD-based dynamic rank allocation [14].

FFA-LoRA [21] froze one factor at its random initialization and showed that this improves stability in privacy-preserving federated fine-tuning. We adopt the same frozen-factor property for a stronger reason. When the frozen factor is identical across clients, averaging the trainable factor gives exact coordinate-wise averaging of the active induced-update slices, as Proposition 3 shows, and each client uploads only that factor. It thereby removes the factor-rotation ambiguity that makes joint factor averaging differ from update averaging. Section 4.4 develops this aggregation.

SA-FedLoRA schedules rank over rounds without conditioning on link state [15]. FedSA-LoRA studies asymmetric factor aggregation with client-local parameters [22]. Across these systems, the rank responds to training progress, parameter importance, or device capability; in none of them is it a decision variable conditioned on the delivery state of a deadline-constrained link. We evaluate an annealing baseline and joint A/B averaging while making rank a per-round decision conditioned on delivery state and deadline.

2.2. Communication-efficient federated learning

A broad literature reduces FL communication through sparsification, quantization, compressed sensing, and over-the-air aggregation [23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28]. These methods compress a given update. Our scheduler selects its rank before transmission, so rank directly affects payload and deadline

feasibility. The proposed capacity and delivery models can therefore be combined with other codecs.

2.3. Client selection and deadline-aware scheduling

Client selection improves FL efficiency under data, latency, and energy heterogeneity. Oort ranks candidates by a utility that couples data value with system efficiency [29]; FedCS selects clients under explicit resource constraints [30]; TiFL groups clients into latency tiers to bound stragglers [31]; further designs target cost and freshness [32, 33, 34]. A second line makes participation deadline- and reliability-aware in mobile and non-terrestrial networks [5, 6, 7, 8, 35]: LESSON admits wireless clients at differentiated frequencies under a latency budget [36], and FedSN coordinates federated training across heterogeneous LEO satellite networks [37]. These methods generally treat update size as fixed: participation is decided for a given payload, not jointly with it. We include an Oort-style selector as a selection baseline. FedRAS chooses participation and update rank together, yielding a multiple-choice knapsack.

2.4. Research gap and positioning

Across these lines, a common interface is missing. The rank-adaptation methods of Section 2.1 decide the rank from training state, parameter importance, or device capability; the selection and deadline-aware methods of Section 2.3 decide participation for a fixed update size. Neither treats the LoRA rank as a schedulable network resource whose payload sets the delivery probability on a lossy link, and none formulates the joint client–rank assignment under byte-budget and deadline constraints. Table 1 positions FedRAS against the closest systems along these dimensions.

We do not claim each ingredient individually as new. Our contribution is their combination: the LoRA rank treated as a deadline-constrained network resource with an explicit payload-conditioned delivery hazard, a client–rank assignment that is exact on the stated budget grid with quantified greedy gaps and solver cost, and validation with a real federated trainer in which adapters are placed on every block of the backbone and all byte accounting uses real serialized sizes. The theoretical contribution is mechanism correctness rather than a learning-performance guarantee: exactness of the assignment on the stated grid (Proposition 1) and exactness of frozen-factor aggregation (Proposition 3), each with its scope conditions stated where it

Table 1: Positioning against the closest federated LoRA and client-selection systems. Cell entries reflect the cited papers' own descriptions; "link-aware" means that a scheduling or adaptation decision conditions on network delivery state (rate, deadline, delivery probability) rather than on training progress or device capability alone; for fixed-rank systems the aggregation column is not applicable (—); n/r means not reported.

System	Rank decision	Link-aware	Het.-rank aggregation	Joint adm.+rank	Payload accounting	Real training
FFA-LoRA [21]	fixed	—	—	—	parameter count	✓
SLoRA [10]	fixed	—	—	—	parameter count	✓
HetLoRA [12]	per client/round	—	zero-padding, sparsity-weighted	—	parameter count	✓
HeLoRA [13]	per client	—	zero-padding, KD variants	n/r	parameter count	✓
FedARA [14]	per layer/round	—	threshold mask arbitration	—	parameter count	✓
SA-FedLoRA [15]	per round	—	n/r	—	parameter count	n/r
FedSA-LoRA [22]	fixed	—	—	—	parameter count	✓
Oort [29]	none (rank fixed)	runtime profile	—	✓(admission)	runtime profile	✓
FedRAS (ours)	per client/round	✓	frozen-A rank masking	✓(joint MCKP)	real serialized sizes	✓

applies. The claim is conditional on the surveyed literature of Section 2 and on the evaluated setting.

3. System model and threat model

3.1. Mobile-edge federated learning architecture and round protocol

We consider a mobile edge network in which an edge aggregator serves a client set $\mathcal{D} = \mathcal{D}_g \cup \mathcal{D}_a \cup \mathcal{D}_s$ of ground clients $\mathcal{D}_g$, aerial and UAV clients $\mathcal{D}_a$, and satellite-connected clients $\mathcal{D}_s$. Ground links are comparatively stable, aerial links face frequent handover, and satellite links suffer long propagation delay, intermittent visibility, and outages [4, 5]. The aggregator holds the global model, schedules every round, and aggregates the timely updates.

Let w^t denote the frozen backbone broadcast at round t. Client i trains LoRA factors $A_{i,\ell}$ and $B_{i,\ell}$ for the adapted layers $\ell \in \mathcal{L}$, with effective weight change $\Delta W_{i,\ell} = B_{i,\ell} A_{i,\ell}$. A rank r update uses the first r columns of $B_{i,\ell}$ and the matching rows of the shared A. Fig. 1 shows the resulting round pipeline. In every round, the aggregator estimates the link states, constructs and filters the client–rank actions, and solves the assignment with the grid-based dynamic program of Section 4; the admitted clients train locally with their factors sliced to the assigned rank, so only the first r coordinates receive gradient updates, and upload before the deadline τ; the aggregator then aggregates the timely updates with data-size weights and updates its link-state history from the observed outcomes. Late or lost updates are discarded, because stale updates harm convergence stability in deadline-critical federated learning. The experiments evaluate both a homogeneous link profile and a

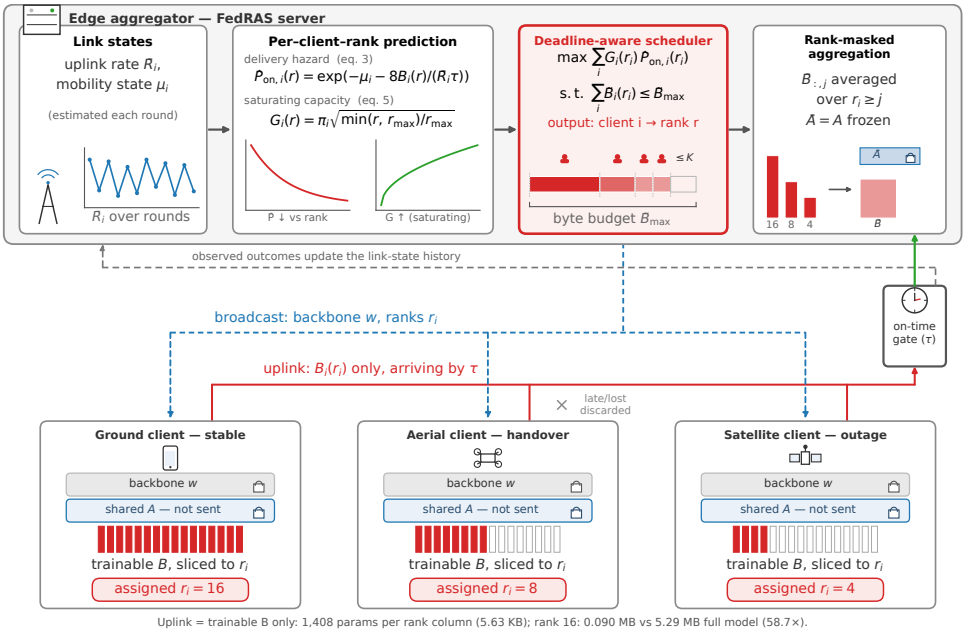


Figure 1: FedRAS system architecture and round pipeline. The edge aggregator scores every client–rank pair with the delivery hazard (3) and the saturating capacity (5), and computes the client–rank assignment with the grid-based dynamic program under the byte budget and the admission cap. Updates arriving within the deadline τ pass the on-time gate and are aggregated with rank-masked averaging while the shared factor A stays frozen; observed outcomes update the link-state history.

grouped ground–aerial–satellite profile with distinct rate and mobility laws (Section 6).

3.2. Link, mobility, and timely-delivery model

At decision time the scheduler receives an estimated uplink rate $\bar{R}_i^t$ in Mbps and a mobility state. The realized rate R_i^t, handover event $H_i^t \in \{0, 1\}$, and packet loss indicator J_i^t are not observed before transmission. For an update of $B_i^t(r)$ megabytes, the modeled delivery time is

$$T_i^t(r) = T_{\text{train,i}}(r) + T_{\text{proc,i}}(r) + \frac{8B_i^t(r)}{R_i^t} + d_i^t + H_i^t \Delta d_h. \tag{1}$$

Timely delivery is the event

$$P_{\text{on,i}}^t(r) = \Pr\left(T_i^t(r) \le \tau,\ J_i^t = 0 \mid x_i^t\right). \tag{2}$$

The implementation uses the following hazard surrogate rather than a derived distribution for all terms in (1).

$$\hat{P}^t_{\mathrm{on,i}}(r) = \exp\big(-\mu_i^t\big)\exp\Big(-\frac{8B_i^t(r)}{\bar{R}_i^t\tau}\Big). \tag{3}$$

The dimensionless intensity μ_i^t summarizes mobility-related failure risk, packet loss, handover effects, and unmodeled processing time; it is a fixed surrogate rather than an estimated distribution in the present implementation, and (3) is used as a plug-in predictor throughout. The construction of the estimated states and the sensitivity studies are specified in Section 6; how far the conclusions survive this idealization is delimited in Section 7.

3.3. Rank-dependent payload and adaptation capacity

With b bits per parameter and the frozen factor A shared and never transmitted, a rank-r client uploads only the trainable factor B, whose per-rank cost is the summed output dimension $D = \sum_{\ell\in\mathcal{L}} d_\ell$ of the adapted layers. The real serialized payload is

$$B_i^t(r) = \frac{b}{8}\, r\, D + B_{\mathrm{meta}}, \tag{4}$$

in bytes. Rank is therefore a network-visible resource: it scales both the adaptation capacity and the transmission time, and its per-unit payload is audited against the evaluated model in Section 6. We model the useful contribution of a delivered rank-r update with the saturating capacity gain

$$G_i^t(r) = \pi_i^t\,\sqrt{\min(r, r_{\max})/r_{\max}}, \tag{5}$$

where π_i^t is a per-client contribution prior in the spirit of Oort-style utility [29]. The width $r_{\max}$ is the factor width provisioned at all clients. The square root encodes the diminishing returns of rank that the delivered-update norms exhibit directly in the trainer (Section 6), and the saturation at $r_{\max}$ reflects that wider factors add payload but no expressible capacity once the provisioned width is reached. Full-parameter FedAvg updates are accounted at their true serialized size (Table 2).

3.4. Adversary and trust model

Clients are honest but curious: they follow the training protocol, and raw data never leaves the devices, which is the standing premise of federated

learning on this infrastructure. The edge aggregator is trusted scheduling infrastructure: it observes link states, client–rank assignments, and delivered update factors, and runs the aggregation of Section 4.4. The external adversary of interest is an eavesdropper on the wireless uplink who observes the transmitted B factors. Because the shared factor A is never transmitted and a rank-r client transmits only its first r coordinates, the exposed gradient-inversion surface is the B-slice of the assigned rank, of strictly smaller dimensionality than a full-model or joint-factor update. Under this model, FedRAS optimizes communication efficiency and proposes no protection mechanism: differential-privacy accounting, secure aggregation, and Byzantine robustness are orthogonal and out of scope (Section 7).

3.5. Deadline-constrained client–rank scheduling formulation

Each round, the aggregator decides $a_i^t \in \{0\} \cup \mathcal{R}$, where $a_i^t = 0$ means client i does not participate and $a_i^t = r$ schedules it at rank r. The per-round problem is

$$\max_{\{a_i^t\}} \sum_{i \in \mathcal{D}} \mathbf{1}\{a_i^t > 0\}\, G_i^t(a_i^t)\, P_{\mathrm{on,i}}^t(a_i^t) \tag{6}$$

$$\text{s.t.} \quad \sum_i B_i^t(a_i^t) \le B_{\max}, \qquad \sum_i \mathbf{1}\{a_i^t > 0\} \le K. \tag{7}$$

The objective is a scheduling utility: expected useful delivered updates under the byte budget $B_{\max}$ and the participation cap K. It is a network-side objective, not a surrogate for final test accuracy; increasing r raises G sublinearly while raising payload and lowering the delivery surrogate. The experiments therefore report test accuracy, timely delivery ratio, bytes per round, and mean delivered rank as separate outcomes (Section 6).

4. FedRAS design

4.1. Design overview

FedRAS turns the formulation of Section 3.5 into a per-round scheduling procedure with three components: a discretization that turns the client–rank actions into a multiple-choice knapsack, a grid-based dynamic program that solves the assignment exactly, together with a cheap per-client rule for the unconstrained regime, and a frozen-factor rank-masked aggregation rule for heterogeneous ranks. The next three subsections develop these components in turn; Fig. 1 places them in the round pipeline. The design contains no training-side logic: admissions and ranks are chosen from network state alone.

4.2. From formulation to discrete action space

Each round the aggregator selects, for every client, one action from the discrete set $a_i^t \in \{0\} \cup \mathcal{R}$ of Section 3.5. The per-rank payload follows (4), and the estimated utility of admitting client i at rank r is $u_i(r) = G_i^t(r)\hat{P}_{\text{on,i}}^t(r)$. All budget arithmetic uses a conservative ceiling discretization onto a budget grid q, with integer cost $\widetilde{B}_i(r) = \lceil B_i^t(r)/q \rceil$, applied identically to the dynamic program, the greedy baselines, and the admission checks, so that every scheduling method optimizes over the identical feasible region. Under this discretization, the single-round estimated problem (6)–(7) is a multiple-choice knapsack with an admission constraint, for which an exact pseudo-polynomial dynamic program exists; the evaluated grid width and its quantization error are quantified in Section 6.3.2.

4.3. Grid-based dynamic-programming scheduler

Let $V_i(k, b)$ be the maximum estimated utility from the first i clients with k admissions and integer budget b. Initialize $V_0(0, 0) = 0$ and all other states to $-\infty$. The recurrence is

$$V_i(k,b) = \max\Big\{V_{i-1}(k,b),\ \max_{r\in\mathcal{R}}\big[V_{i-1}(k-1, b-\widetilde{B}_i(r)) + u_i(r)\big]\Big\}, \qquad (8)$$

where $u_i(r) = G_i^t(r)\hat{P}_{\text{on,i}}^t(r)$. Backpointers recover the assignment. Algorithm 1 summarizes one scheduling round. Propositions 1 and 2 (Section 5) establish the exactness of this recurrence and the regime in which the per-client rule of Section 3.5 is already optimal.

4.4. Frozen-factor rank-masked aggregation

Clients scheduled at different ranks share an $r_{\max}$ coordinate system. For one adapted layer, client i has sample weight n_i and delivered rank r_i. The factor $A \in \mathbb{R}^{r_{\max}\times k}$ is frozen and shared, while $B_i \in \mathbb{R}^{d\times r_{\max}}$ is trainable. A rank r_i update activates columns 1 through r_i of B_i and the matching rows of A, giving $\Delta W_i = \sum_{j\le r_i}[B_i]_{:,j}[A]_{j,:}$.

Jointly trained factor pairs (A_i, B_i) are identifiable only up to invertible transforms, so separately averaged factors need not average the updates at all. The elevated-learning-rate ablation of Section 6 examines this aggregation rule empirically.

Rank-masked averaging. The server zero-pads inactive columns of each delivered B_i and averages each active coordinate over the clients that

Algorithm 1 FedRAS scheduling round

Require: clients $\mathcal{D}$, ranks $\mathcal{R}$, cap K, budget $B_{\max}$, deadline τ, states $\{x_i^t\}$
Ensure: admitted set and assigned ranks

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Estimate P̂^t_{on,i}(r) by (3) and G^t_i(r) by (5) for all i, r
Initialize V_0(0, 0) = 0; other DP states to −∞
for each client i ∈ D do
    for k = 0, ..., K and each budget state b do
        Apply skip and every feasible rank transition of (8)
        Store the maximizing action as a backpointer
    end for
end for
Backtrack from max_{k,b} V_{|D|}(k, b); return the client–rank assignment
Execute the round; aggregate timely rank-masked updates (Section 4.4);
update link-state history
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activate it,

$$\bar{B}_{:,j} = \frac{1}{W_j} \sum_{i:\, r_i \geq j} n_i \left[B_i\right]_{:,j}, \qquad W_j = \sum_{i:\, r_i \geq j} n_i, \tag{9}$$

while the frozen factor aggregates to itself, $\bar{A} = A$. The server then applies momentum per factor tensor. With $\Delta^t = \bar{B} - S^{t-1}$, the velocity and state update as $v^t = \beta\, v^{t-1} + (1-\beta)\, \Delta^t$ and $S^t = S^{t-1} + v^t$, with damping coefficient β absorbing client-sampling and link noise. Proposition 3 (Section 5) states the exactness and dilution properties of this rule.

5. Theoretical analysis

5.1. Exactness of the DP assignment

Proposition 1 (Per-round optimality)**.** *For every reachable state (k, b), recurrence* (8) *considers the skip action and every feasible rank for client i. Induction on i therefore proves exactness for the discretized single round estimated assignment problem.*

Proof. The admission indicator and the rank of each client are exclusive actions that affect the two resources additively. Admitting client i at rank r consumes one admission slot and $\widetilde{B}_i(r)$ budget units and adds $u_i(r)$ value, independent of the other clients. The state (k, b) therefore summarizes all interaction, and the standard interchange argument for the multiple-choice

knapsack applies. Any optimal solution restricted to the first $i-1$ clients must itself be optimal for its state, which the recurrence maximizes. □

5.2. Optimality condition of the per-client rule

The formulation also yields a condition under which the cheap per-client rule of Section 3.5 is already optimal, which the trainer experiments of Section 6.2.5 rely on.

Proposition 2 (Cohort-local optimality of the per-client rule)**.** *Consider the single-round problem* (6)–(7) *restricted to a fixed candidate set, and suppose the all-$r_{\max}$ rank profile is budget-feasible, i.e., $\sum_i \widetilde{B}_i(r_{\max}) \le \widetilde{B}_{\max}$ over the candidates. Then the profile that assigns every admitted client its per-client maximizer $r_i^\star = \arg\max_{r\in\mathcal{R}} G_i(r)\hat{P}_{\mathrm{on},i}(r)$ is a feasible optimal solution of the restricted problem.*

Proof. Each candidate's cost is at most its $r_{\max}$ cost, so the per-client maximizer profile satisfies the budget whenever the all-$r_{\max}$ profile does, and it uses no more than the cap. Being feasible, it attains $\sum_i \max_r u_i(r)$, which upper-bounds the objective of every feasible profile; it is therefore optimal. By Proposition 1, the dynamic program returns an optimal profile and hence coincides with the per-client maximizer profile whenever the latter is unique. □

5.3. Exactness of frozen-factor aggregation

Proposition 3 (Exactness of frozen-factor aggregation)**.** *Under* (9)*, the j-th active rank slice of $\bar{B}A$ is the data-weighted average over clients with $r_i \ge j$. This is exact coordinate-wise averaging of active induced-update slices. It is not, in general, the unified data-weighted average of complete client updates. If a common denominator $W = \sum_i n_i$ is used instead of W_j, the unified average is recovered, but active high-rank slices are diluted by W_j/W. The two rules coincide for all possible updates when all delivered ranks are equal.*

Proof. The first two parts follow from linearity. For frozen shared A, multiplying a weighted sum of B-coordinates by $\big[A\big]_{j,:}$ converts it into the same weighted sum of the matching update slices, and the two normalizers differ only in W_j versus W. The product $\bar{B}A = \sum_j \bar{B}_{:,j}\big[A\big]_{j,:}$ collects the slices. The third part holds because $W_j = W$ for every active j if and only if $r_i = \max_k r_k$ for all admitted i with $n_i > 0$. □

5.4. Complexity and scope of the analysis

The complexity is $O(|\mathcal{D}|K\widetilde{B}_{\max}|\mathcal{R}|)$ time and $O(K\widetilde{B}_{\max})$ memory with rolling value arrays; the back-pointer table retained for reconstruction adds $O(|\mathcal{D}|K\widetilde{B}_{\max})$, where $\widetilde{B}_{\max} = \lceil B_{\max}/q \rceil$. Section 6.3.2 reports the resulting runtimes at 500- and 1000-client scale.

Scope of the analysis. The exactness results concern the discretized single-round estimated assignment problem and the frozen-factor aggregation rule. They are not claims of optimality for the continuous-budget problem, for the multi-round stochastic control problem, or for final model accuracy, and they do not establish a convergence guarantee for federated training. The practical value of exactness is quantified experimentally in Sections 6.2.5 and 6.3.2.

6. Experimental evaluation

The evaluation tests accuracy and network behavior in a real trainer (Section 5.2), scheduling quality at 500 clients and solver cost (Section 5.3), and sensitivity to payload, predictor, capacity, and budget-grid assumptions (Section 5.4). All byte figures are real serialized sizes, and all deadline regimes are calibrated to those sizes.

6.1. Experimental setup

Environment. The trainer is implemented in PyTorch, and all real-training runs use one NVIDIA A800 GPU.

Datasets and partitions. Experiments use CIFAR-10, CIFAR-100, and MNIST. The real trainer partitions 20 clients non-IID with Dirichlet $\alpha = 0.5$ and samples 10 participants per round; variations of α and of the mobility distribution are reported in Table 5 and Section 6.4.

Backbone and adapters. The backbone is a six-convolution BatchNorm CNN with channel progression 64/128/256, followed by two 256-wide linear layers. It is centrally pretrained with crop, flip, and erase augmentation, Nesterov momentum, weight decay, and cosine learning-rate decay, for 30 epochs on CIFAR-10, 45 on CIFAR-100, and 3 on MNIST, and then frozen, reaching a test accuracy of 0.914, 0.693, and 0.995, respectively. LoRA adapters with candidate rank set $\mathcal{R} = \{2, 4, 8, 16\}$ and provisioned width $r_{\max} = 16$ are placed on all six convolutions through 1×1 factors and on both head layers; a client assigned rank r trains with its factors sliced

Table 2: Payload audit of real serialized update sizes. Frozen-A clients upload only the trainable B factor (1,408 parameters per rank column); the A+B column is the joint-training equivalent. The stylized $s(r)$ column lists the protocol reused as a normalized-cost cell in Section 6.3.1.

Rank r	A+B FP32 (MB)	B-only FP32 (MB)	B-only FP16 (MB)	Stylized $s(r)$ (MB)
2	0.021	0.011	0.006	0.54
4	0.041	0.023	0.011	0.58
8	0.082	0.045	0.023	0.66
16	0.164	0.090	0.045	0.82
Full model	5.29 MB FP32 (58.7× the rank-16 B-only upload)			

to the first r coordinates, so the rank genuinely bounds local adaptation capacity.

Federated training hyperparameters. Federated training runs for 40 rounds with one local epoch and batch size 128. Local SGD uses learning rate 0.005, weight decay 10^{-4}, gradient clipping at 1, and cosine decay. The server applies rank-masked weighted averaging with momentum β=0.3, the coefficient of Section 4.4.

Link models. Uplink rates are drawn from LogNormal$(2.5, 0.7)$ clipped to $[1, 40]$ Mbps and mobility from Beta$(2, 5)$, redrawn each round; a grouped ground–aerial–satellite profile with distinct rate and mobility laws per class is evaluated separately. These generated states are supplied to the scheduler as oracle estimates; no calibration on measured traces is performed (Section 7).

Deadline calibration. All deadline regimes are calibrated to the real payloads. The nominal round deadline is 2.0 s, at which transmission time consumes only 3% of a rank-16 update's delivery probability at the median 12 Mbps rate, while a full-model update already misses 83% of its deadlines. The stress deadlines are 0.1 s and 0.05 s, at which rank-16 timely delivery falls to 0.41 and 0.27 while rank-4 retains 0.62 and 0.57, so downshifting is genuinely load-bearing. A loose 10 s control restores full-model timely delivery to 0.52.

Model and payload audit. Table 2 audits the actual serialized sizes against the evaluated model. The frozen backbone has 1.28M parameters. Each adapted layer contributes a frozen-A and a trainable-B slice per rank column; only B is transmitted, at D=1,408 parameters per rank column across the eight adapted layers. A rank-16 client therefore uploads 0.090 MB, against 5.29 MB for a full-model update.

Simulator. The 500-client, 150-round scheduler simulation uses the

same delivery and capacity models with uniform cohort sampling, per-client rank selection, and budget admission on the same ceiling grid. It covers nominal, deadline, budget, mobility, and 1000-client scalability regimes, with five seeds and common traces. Its accuracy column is a bounded scheduling proxy driven by delivered useful value, not a dataset accuracy; the full-update baseline receives the same capacity credit as rank 16 under the saturating model, a disclosed modeling assumption. A separate cell repeats the earlier stylized protocol ($s(r) = 0.02r + 0.5$ MB, rank-64 full-update stand-in, 0.25 s deadline, 12 MB budget) as a normalized-cost sensitivity check.

Scoring proxy. The simulator samples π_i uniformly from $[0.15, 0.45]$ and uses a bounded scheduling proxy rather than dataset accuracy. Starting at 0.1, it updates as $a^{t+1} = a^t + \eta\hat{g}^t(1 - a^t) - \varepsilon a^t + \omega^t$, where $\hat{g}^t$ is useful delivered value normalized by K, $\eta = 0.08$, $\varepsilon = 0.0005$, and $\omega^t \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 5 \times 10^{-4})$ is a small tie-breaking noise.

Solver study. The solver study runs 30 instances per deadline and budget cell at 500 clients, on a q=0.01 MB ceiling grid. It compares the grid-based DP with value-per-byte greedy, value greedy, a cohort-myopic rule, and fixed rank 16, and adds a client-count sweep that extends to 1000 clients. Budgets are 30 MB (slack), 4 MB, and 1.2 MB; the last admits only twelve rank-16 updates on the ceiling grid of the cap K=25 and is therefore binding.

Baselines. FedRAS is compared against fixed ranks r=4 and r=16, a random-rank policy, and full-model FedAvg updates (referred to as full-model updates throughout, trained at a 0.4× local learning-rate scale). Three external baselines are included: an SA-FedLoRA-style schedule that heats the rank from 2 to 16 and cools it down over the 40 rounds, oblivious to link state [15]; an Oort-style selector that samples $2K$ candidates and admits the top-K by a data-size-and-recency utility at fixed rank [29]; and joint A/B training with plain averaging, the aggregation-level competitor of Section 4.4 [22]. A delivery-only ablation (reliability-only) removes the capacity term. All methods share client partitions, generated link states, deadline, and seed protocol; where applicable they share the local optimizer and rank set.

Scheduling variants. Two deployment variants of the formulation are evaluated. In full grid scheduling, the aggregator solves (6) and (7) over all clients; the solver study evaluates this variant at 500-client scale, and a same-cohort variant restricts the dynamic program to a uniformly sampled cohort, isolating the value of candidate-pool widening from in-cohort rank allocation. In the real trainer, fair-cohort scheduling samples the fixed cohort

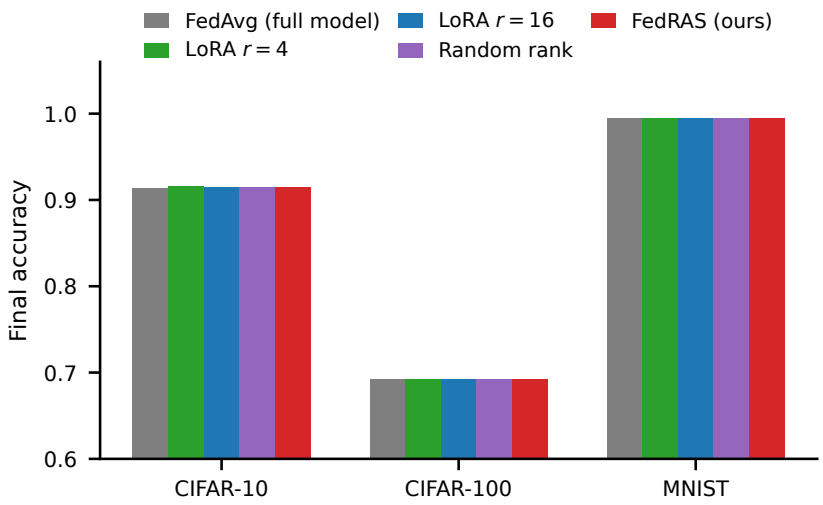


Figure 2: Final accuracy across datasets. CIFAR-10 uses ten seeds; CIFAR-100 and MNIST use five seeds. The parity and equivalence findings of Table 3 are not CIFAR-10-specific.

of ten clients and applies the per-client rank rule $r_i^\star = \arg\max_r G_i^t(r) P_{\mathrm{on,i}}^t(r)$. Section 6.2.5 compares the variants in the trainer.

Metrics. Four outcomes are reported throughout: test accuracy at round 40; timely delivery ratio, the timely deliveries of a method divided by its selected clients; bytes per round, counting attempted uplink payloads including late and failed uploads at real serialized sizes; and mean delivered rank over delivered updates. The simulator reports its bounded utility state, the mean delivery probability of admitted clients, and attempted payload totals (Table 9). No quantization, sparsification, energy, or fairness metric is claimed in this study.

Statistical protocol. Results use five seeds (0 through 4) with common random numbers within each seed; the CIFAR-10 nominal and 0.1 s regimes, their external baselines, and the scheduling-arm comparison at the nominal deadline use ten seeds. Headline trainer comparisons use two-sided Wilcoxon tests on seed pairs, seed-mean bootstrap confidence intervals, and a pre-registered TOST equivalence test at a ± 0.5 percentage-point margin. Simulator comparisons without an accompanying test are descriptive.

Table 3: Real trainer on non-IID CIFAR-10 at the nominal 2.0 s deadline with ten seeds. Accuracy is measured at round 40. Timely delivery ratio is timely deliveries divided by selected clients. Bytes per round is the sum of attempted uplink payloads for selected clients over rounds 30 to 39, at real serialized sizes. Mean rank is computed over delivered updates.

Method	Accuracy	Timely delivery ratio	MB/round	Mean rank
FedAvg (full model)	0.9135 ± 0.0027	0.17	52.86	—
FedLoRA r=4	0.9154 ± 0.0016	0.75	0.23	4.0
FedLoRA r=16	0.9153 ± 0.0015	0.73	0.90	16.0
Random rank	0.9151 ± 0.0016	0.76	0.42	7.3
FedRAS (ours)	0.9153 ± 0.0016	0.73	0.90	16.0

6.2. Evaluation with the federated LoRA trainer

6.2.1. Accuracy parity and rank invariance

Table 3 reports ten-seed means and standard deviations after 40 federated rounds on CIFAR-10. All LoRA methods hold the backbone accuracy within one standard deviation of 0.914, whether the rank is fixed at 4, fixed at 16, drawn at random, or selected by the rank rule. Full-parameter updates spend 58.7× the bytes of a rank-16 update, and they lose roughly three quarters of their timely deliveries, 0.17 against 0.73, because their 5.29 MB payloads rarely fit the round deadline. The cross-dataset results in Fig. 2 agree at 0.693 on CIFAR-100 and 0.995 on MNIST. At the nominal deadline the rank rule selects rank 16 for every client of every round, so FedRAS coincides with fixed rank 16 in bytes and timeliness, and in accuracy up to floating-point nondeterminism; this identity, rather than a tuned advantage, is what the nominal regime is meant to show. Fig. 3 shows the corresponding trajectories, stable over the 40 rounds for every rank policy.

6.2.2. Deadline stress

Delivered-rank adaptation. Table 4 tightens the deadline to 0.1 s and 0.05 s. Three effects emerge. First, FedRAS downshifts under pressure. Its delivered mean rank falls from 16.0 at the nominal deadline to 12.7 at 0.1 s and 8.1 at 0.05 s, where the delivery hazard (3) makes rank-16 payloads marginal. Second, downshifting pays. At 0.1 s, FedRAS delivers 0.49 timely updates against 0.41 for fixed rank 16 while transmitting 0.69 MB against 0.90 MB, i.e., 23% fewer bytes; at 0.05 s the gap widens to 0.49 against 0.27 timely deliveries at 51% fewer bytes. Third, full-parameter updates collapse completely. Their timely delivery ratio is 0.00 at both stress deadlines, so

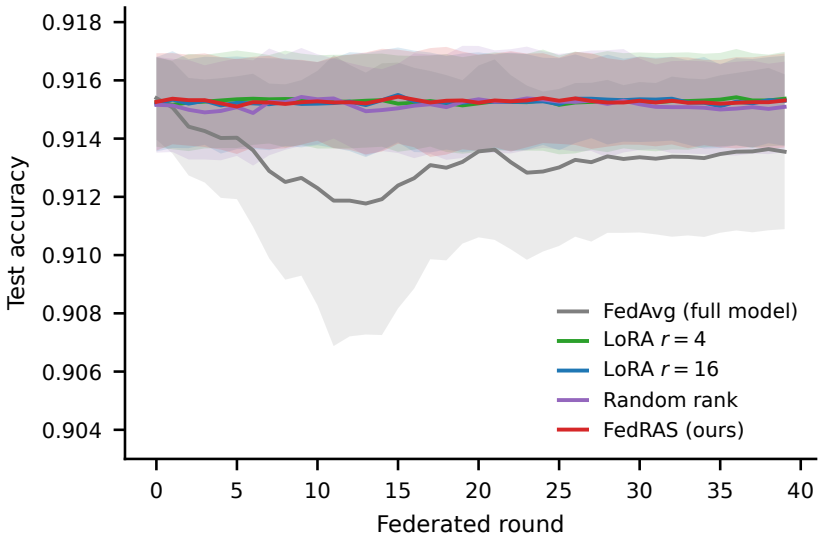


Figure 3: Real-trainer CIFAR-10 test accuracy over 40 federated rounds at the nominal deadline (mean over ten seeds). All rank policies hold the pretrained-backbone accuracy; differences appear in bytes and timeliness, not accuracy.

not a single full-size update arrives on time.

Mechanism and replication. Accuracy spreads remain within about two standard deviations, which is consistent with the parity claim. The scheduling metrics are where the methods separate. Fig. 5 shows the ten-seed stress trajectories, and Fig. 4 visualizes the mechanism directly: the delivered rank of FedRAS holds 16 under the nominal deadline, tracks 13 under the 0.1 s deadline, and tracks 8 under the 0.05 s deadline, whereas the annealed baseline follows its fixed heat–cool path regardless of link state. Under the statistical protocol of Section 6, the ten-seed replication confirms these differences at conventional significance levels: at the 0.1 s deadline, FedRAS transmits 23% fewer bytes than fixed r=16, with a seed-mean bootstrap 95% confidence interval of roughly $[-27\%, -21\%]$ and a two-sided Wilcoxon p of 0.002; it delivers a higher timely delivery ratio in ten of ten seed pairs, by 22% on average; and its accuracy is statistically equivalent within the pre-registered margin.

6.2.3. Extended stress matrix

Table 5 extends the study along further axes. A mobility-only scenario with Beta$(0.7, 5)$ mobility at the nominal deadline leaves all LoRA policies

Table 4: Real trainer under deadline stress. Accuracy is the round-40 mean and standard deviation. Timely delivery ratio, bytes per round, and mean delivered rank are averaged over rounds 30 to 39 at real serialized sizes. The 0.1 s columns use ten seeds; the 0.05 s columns use five seeds.

	deadline 0.1 s				deadline 0.05 s			
Method	Acc.	Timely	MB	Rank	Acc.	Timely	MB	Rank
FedAvg (full model)	$0.9153 \pm .0015$	0.00	52.86	—	$0.9147 \pm .0016$	0.00	52.86	—
FedLoRA r=4	$0.9154 \pm .0016$	0.62	0.23	4	$0.9144 \pm .0015$	0.57	0.23	4
FedLoRA r=16	$0.9149 \pm .0019$	0.41	0.90	16	$0.9143 \pm .0020$	0.27	0.90	16
Random rank	$0.9153 \pm .0017$	0.56	0.42	6.2	$0.9143 \pm .0015$	0.46	0.42	5.7
FedRAS (ours)	$0.9154 \pm .0018$	0.49	0.69	12.7	$0.9143 \pm .0014$	0.49	0.44	8.1

Table 5: Extended stress matrix. Results use five seeds and report round-40 accuracy as mean over seeds. The mobility-only and α=1.0 scenarios probe extreme conditions; the last two columns repeat the 0.1 s deadline on CIFAR-100 and MNIST.

Scenario	FedAvg	r=4	r=16	Random	FedRAS
deadline 10 s	0.9134	0.9144	0.9145	0.9141	0.9143
mobility 0.7	0.9115	0.9143	0.9141	0.9145	0.9141
α=0.1	0.9022	0.9139	0.9107	0.9130	0.9109
α=1.0	0.9142	0.9143	0.9144	0.9141	0.9144
CIFAR-100, 2.0 s	0.6925	0.6928	0.6926	0.6926	0.6929
CIFAR-100, 0.1 s	0.6927	0.6927	0.6929	0.6927	0.6928
MNIST, 2.0 s	0.9947	0.9949	0.9951	0.9950	0.9951
MNIST, 0.1 s	0.9947	0.9949	0.9950	0.9949	0.9950

at parity, so mobility alone does not force downshifting at this deadline. Extreme label heterogeneity with α=0.1 reveals a second-order effect: rank-16 updates lose 0.32 percentage points relative to rank 4 (0.9107 versus 0.9139), consistent with capacity-amplified client drift, and full-parameter updates lose the most (0.9022). FedRAS follows the rank-16 trajectory here, so a heterogeneity-aware downshift is a natural extension. Loosening the deadline to 10 s restores full-model timely delivery to 0.52 without changing any LoRA accuracy. Repeating the 0.1 s deadline on CIFAR-100 and MNIST reproduces the CIFAR-10 stress picture. The scheduling conclusions are therefore not dataset-specific.

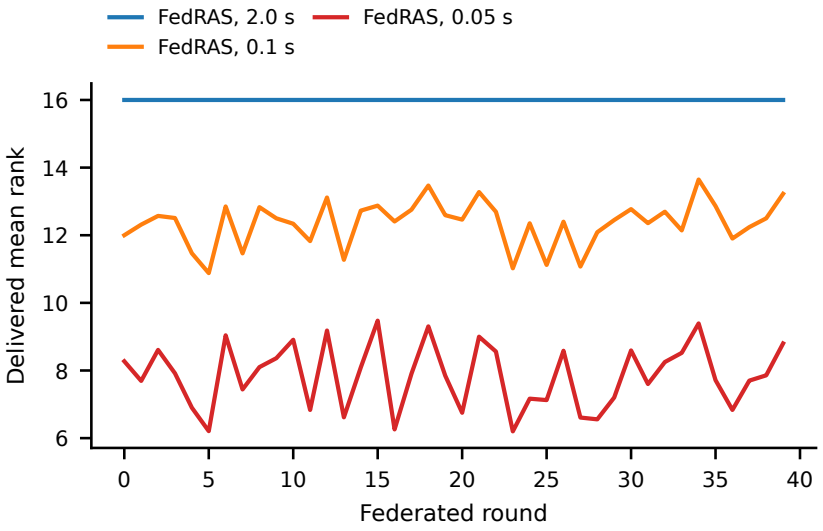


Figure 4: Delivered mean rank per round for FedRAS under three deadlines (ten seeds for 2.0 s and 0.1 s, five seeds for 0.05 s), against the fixed annealing schedule of the SA-FedLoRA-style baseline at 0.1 s. FedRAS is link-aware, holding high rank when possible and downshifting under pressure.

6.2.4. External baselines

Baseline behavior. Table 6 reports the three external baselines of the setup in the real trainer. The link-oblivious annealing schedule settles at low rank and therefore buys timely delivery with only 0.29 MB per round, but it cannot increase rank when links improve, and its capacity ceiling is rank 5. The Oort-style selector improves selection at fixed rank. Joint A/B training matches frozen-factor training at the adopted learning rate, and the ablations find no stability separation at an elevated learning rate either, so the case for the frozen factor rests on exactness and upload reduction rather than on an observed stability gap.

6.2.5. Scheduling variants

Arms under evaluation. To attribute the value of exact scheduling, the three arms defined in the setup are compared in the real trainer, over ten seeds at the nominal deadline and five seeds under stress. The full grid arm solves the dynamic program of Section 4 over the entire 20-client population under the participation cap and a 1.0 MB budget, which equals ten rank-16 grid costs, so the budget binds only through downshifting or skipping. The

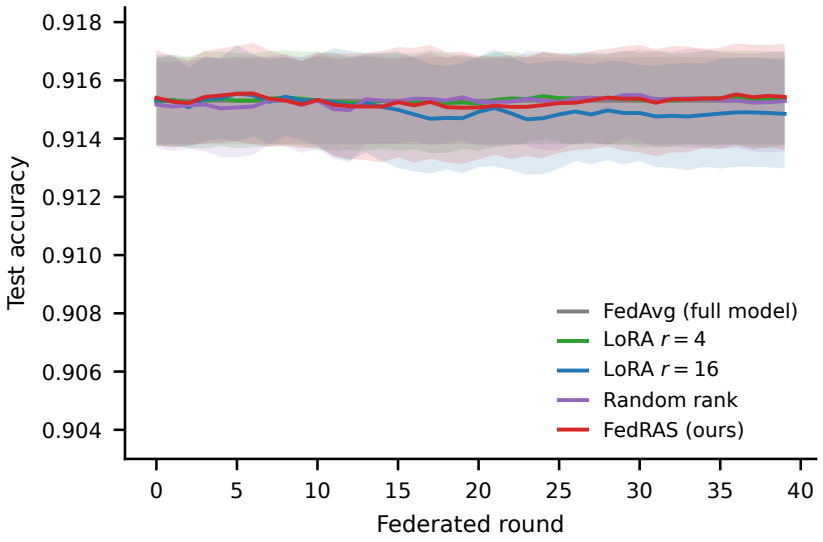


Figure 5: Real-trainer accuracy trajectories under the 0.1 s deadline (mean over ten seeds). All methods remain stable; full-model updates deliver nothing and stay at the backbone.

same-cohort arm draws the identical cohort as fair cohort and restricts the same dynamic program to those candidates.

Where exactness pays. Table 7 yields a clean decomposition. At the nominal deadline, the same-cohort DP coincides exactly with the per-client argmax rule, as Proposition 2 predicts when the all-rank-16 profile fits the budget; the full DP's timely-delivery gain (+9 percentage points) comes entirely from admission over the wider candidate pool. Under the 0.1 s deadline the pattern persists: the in-cohort DP matches the argmax rule, while the full DP delivers more timely updates at proportionally more bytes (Table 7). Exactness therefore pays through admission control over a heterogeneous pool, not through rank allocation inside a cohort, where the cheap per-client rule is already optimal (Proposition 2). This delimits when full grid scheduling is worth its coordination cost.

6.2.6. Component ablations

Component contributions. Table 8 reports component ablations at the nominal deadline. In the parity regime, no removal measurably changes final accuracy, which is consistent with the claim that accuracy is carried by the backbone and not by the scheduler. The components instead shape scheduling behavior and aggregation correctness. Removing the capacity

Table 6: External baselines in the real trainer on non-IID CIFAR-10 with ten seeds. Accuracy is measured at round 40. Timely delivery ratio, bytes, and delivered mean rank are averaged over rounds 30–39.

	nominal deadline				deadline 0.1 s			
Method	Acc.	Timely	MB	Rank	Acc.	Timely	MB	Rank
SA-FedLoRA-style annealing	$0.9154 \pm .0016$	0.75	0.29	5.1	$0.9153 \pm .0016$	0.62	0.29	5.0
Oort-style utility, fixed rank	$0.9150 \pm .0020$	0.76	0.45	8.0	$0.9149 \pm .0019$	0.54	0.45	8.0
Joint A/B, plain averaging	$0.9152 \pm .0016$	0.73	0.90	16	$0.9148 \pm .0019$	0.41	0.90	16
FedLoRA r=16	$0.9153 \pm .0015$	0.73	0.90	16	$0.9149 \pm .0019$	0.41	0.90	16
FedRAS (ours)	$0.9153 \pm .0016$	0.73	0.90	16.0	$0.9154 \pm .0018$	0.49	0.69	12.7

Table 7: Scheduling arms in the real trainer. Top: nominal 2.0 s deadline over ten seeds. Bottom: 0.1 s deadline over five seeds. Both arms of each comparison share the candidate protocol described in the text.

Method	Accuracy	Timely	MB	Rank
nominal 2.0 s, ten seeds				
Full DP (grid assignment, 1.0 MB)	$0.9151 \pm .0016$	0.82	0.90	16.0
Same-cohort DP (1.0 MB)	$0.9152 \pm .0019$	0.73	0.90	16.0
Fair cohort (FedRAS rule)	$0.9153 \pm .0016$	0.73	0.90	16.0
FedLoRA r=16	$0.9153 \pm .0015$	0.73	0.90	16
stress 0.1 s, five seeds				
Full DP (grid assignment, 1.0 MB)	$0.9138 \pm .0011$	0.55	0.87	15.4
Same-cohort DP (1.0 MB)	$0.9139 \pm .0014$	0.51	0.70	12.7
Fair cohort (FedRAS rule)	$0.9144 \pm .0018$	0.51	0.70	13.0

term collapses FedRAS to the minimum rank, the degenerate delivery-only policy that the capacity term exists to prevent; its capacity cost is invisible at nominal deadlines but material in the simulator, where reliability-only optimization loses 28 points of utility against rank 16 (Table 9). Removing server momentum is accuracy-neutral here. The rank mask itself is network-metric-neutral at fixed rank policy: with the random-rank rule at the 0.1 s deadline, masked and unmasked aggregation give 0.9143 and 0.9145 final accuracy with identical byte and timeliness profiles. The mask is nonetheless what keeps heterogeneous-rank aggregation per-slice exact whenever ranks mix, as Proposition 3 states, and its absence dilutes high-rank coordinates under mixed-rank rounds.

Stability at elevated learning rate. Under the elevated learning rate

Table 8: Component ablations, real trainer (non-IID CIFAR-10, five seeds, nominal deadline). The Min. column is the minimum over rounds of the per-round seed-mean accuracy in the elevated-learning-rate stability check at learning rate 0.02.

Configuration	Accuracy	Min.
Full system (ours)	$0.9144 \pm .0013$	—
w/o capacity term	$0.9145 \pm .0014$	—
w/o frozen A (joint A/B)	$0.9144 \pm .0015$	—
w/o rank mask (fixed random rank, 0.1 s)	$0.9145 \pm .0016$	—
w/o server momentum	$0.9143 \pm .0013$	—
frozen A, lr 0.02	$0.9130 \pm .0012$	0.913
joint A/B, lr 0.02	$0.9132 \pm .0012$	0.912

of 0.02, the frozen-factor rule and joint A/B training are statistically indistinguishable, with final accuracies of 0.9130 and 0.9132 and transient minima of 0.913 and 0.912 across rounds and seeds. The stability separation between the two aggregation rules observed in our preliminary stylized-payload experiments does not survive the corrected implementation at this horizon, so the frozen-factor rule is justified by the exactness of Proposition 3 and by its single-factor uploads, not by an empirical stability margin at this scale.

6.3. Large-scale scheduling simulation

6.3.1. Scheduler behavior across operating regimes

Regime comparison. Table 9 summarizes the simulator across regimes, with five seeds at the final round. The accuracy column is the bounded utility state of Section 6, not a dataset accuracy. In the nominal regime, FedRAS matches fixed rank 16 at 0.914 and dominates every low-rank policy. Under the 0.1 s deadline, FedRAS reaches 0.781 against 0.763 for fixed rank 16 at 21% fewer bytes, and full-model updates deliver nothing. Under the binding 1.2 MB budget, full-model updates cannot be admitted even once, while FedRAS and rank 16 tie at 0.797. The mobility-stress and 1000-client regimes show the same pattern. A final cell repeats the stylized protocol of the earlier literature: with the $s(r)$ payload model the ordering is preserved (FedRAS 0.413, rank 16 0.404, annealing 0.374), confirming that the conclusions are not an artifact of the payload accounting.

Table 9: Scheduler simulation with 500 clients, 150 rounds, and five seeds. The accuracy column is a bounded scheduling proxy, not dataset accuracy. Timely delivery ratio is the mean delivery probability for admitted clients, and MB is the attempted uplink payload total for admitted clients in the final round. FedAvg refers to full-model updates at their real 5.29 MB size.

	Nominal 2.0 s			Deadline 0.1 s			Budget 1.2 MB		
Method	Acc.	Timely	MB	Acc.	Timely	MB	Acc.	Timely	MB
FedAvg (full)	.310	.34	26.5	.093	.00	26.5	.093	.00	0.0
r=4	.744	.75	0.8	.689	.64	0.8	.744	.75	0.8
r=16	.914	.73	2.5	.763	.42	2.5	.797	.76	1.2
Random	.816	.75	1.3	.709	.57	1.3	.803	.75	1.2
Reliability-only	.635	.76	0.5	.606	.70	0.5	.635	.76	0.5
SA-annealing	.842	.76	0.5	.730	.70	0.5	.796	.76	0.5
FedRAS (ours)	.914	.73	2.5	**.781**	.50	2.0	**.797**	.76	1.2

Trajectories. Fig. 6 shows the nominal and 0.1 s trajectories, and Fig. 7 the network-side view across regimes. Across the reported regimes, FedRAS is numerically best or tied for best.

6.3.2. Solver optimality and runtime

Heuristic gaps and runtime. Table 10 reports the scheduling study with the identical ceiling discretization for the DP and every heuristic. When the byte budget is slack, value greedy and the fixed rank-16 rule are already optimal, so the choice of scheduler matters little; the value-per-byte greedy, by contrast, collapses to a smallest-rank preference. The interesting regimes are the binding ones: when the budget binds, every heuristic loses a substantial fraction of the objective — up to 64% for value-per-byte pricing — while the DP reaches the optimum of the discretized single-round estimated problem in every cell. Its runtime is sub-second for 500 clients across the evaluated grid widths and scales linearly to 1000 clients, as Fig. 8 shows, which is compatible with per-round scheduling at minute-scale FL rounds.

Grid sweep. A dedicated grid sweep around the default step bounds the quantization error at about 3% in the binding regime and below 1% in slack regimes; a finer step reduces it further at a known runtime cost. The grid exactness claim of Section 5 therefore applies to a grid whose quantization error is bounded, measured, and adjustable.

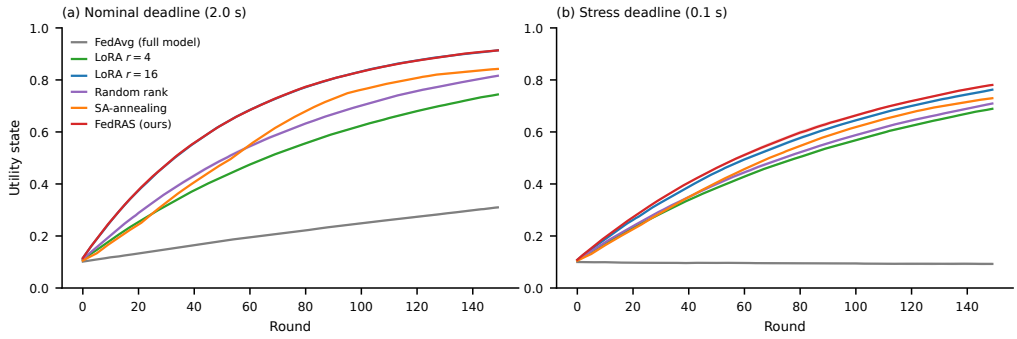


Figure 6: Scheduler simulation utility-state trajectories (mean over five seeds). (a) Nominal 2.0 s deadline, where FedRAS matches fixed rank 16. (b) 0.1 s deadline, where FedRAS downshifting separates from fixed rank 16.

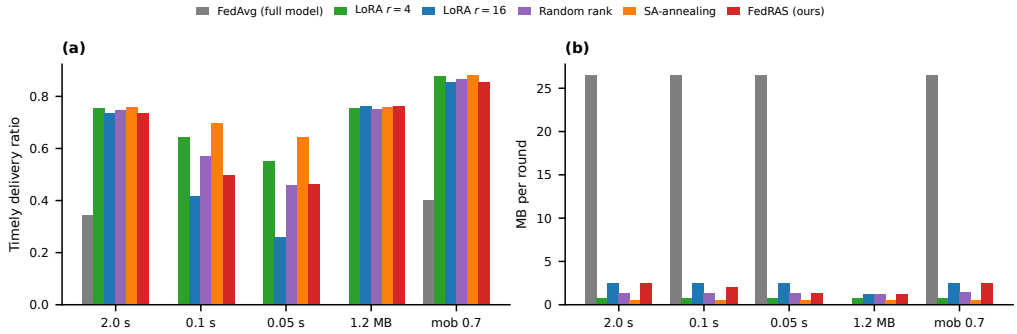


Figure 7: Timely delivery ratio and attempted bytes per method across simulator regimes (five-seed means, final round). Full-model updates deliver nothing under stress and cannot be admitted at all under the binding budget.

6.3.3. Delivery-predictor sensitivity

The calibration study of Fig. 9 measures both the fidelity of the deployed predictor and the scheduling cost of its errors (500 clients). With the oracle link state of the setup, the hazard-form predictor (3) is calibrated by construction. Deliberately distorted variants — power distortions of the predicted probability and multiplicative lognormal noise — are measurably miscalibrated, yet the resulting assignment-objective loss, evaluated under the true probabilities, stays below 1% in every cell. The loss follows the structure of the error: power distortions cost most under the stress deadline, where rank ordering matters most, while noise costs most in the nominal slack cell, where it perturbs an otherwise near-uniform rank preference. Mis-prediction

Table 10: Solver study with 500 clients, K=25, and 30 instances per cell, all methods on the identical ceiling grid. The table reports heuristic objective loss relative to the grid-based DP and DP runtime.

Deadline (s)	Budget (MB)	Greedy val/byte	Greedy value	Cohort myopic	Fixed r=16	DP time (ms)
2.0	30	63.6%	0.0%	40.9%	0.0%	421
2.0	4	63.6%	0.0%	40.9%	0.0%	51
2.0	1.2	47.8%	28.4%	48.9%	28.4%	23
1.0	30	62.7%	0.0%	40.0%	0.0%	415
1.0	4	62.7%	0.0%	43.0%	0.0%	51
1.0	1.2	47.3%	29.3%	48.3%	29.3%	23
0.1	30	52.8%	0.0%	51.9%	0.0%	415
0.1	4	52.6%	0.0%	52.0%	0.0%	51
0.1	1.2	41.0%	36.0%	54.8%	36.0%	23

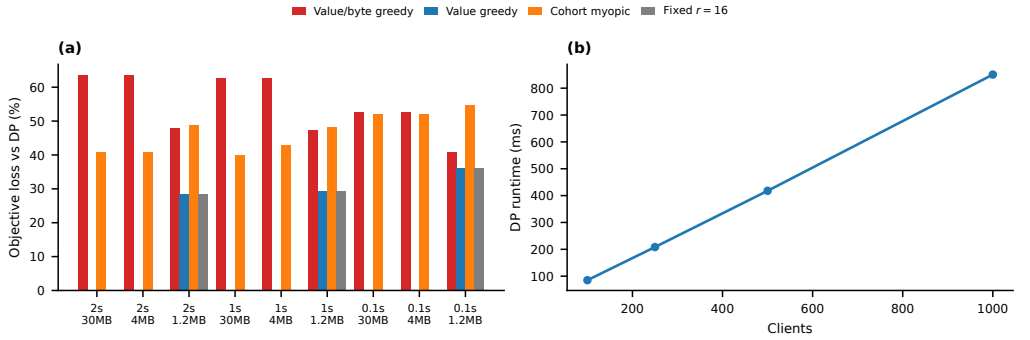


Figure 8: Solver study. (a) Objective loss of the heuristics relative to the DP across deadline and budget cells. (b) DP runtime scaling with the client population.

therefore degrades the objective smoothly rather than catastrophically, and the observed delivery outcomes of Algorithm 1 are exactly the signal from which a per-client predictor would be recalibrated. Calibration on measured traces remains open and is taken up in Section 7.

6.4. Sensitivity and robustness analysis

Width, cohort, and heterogeneity. Fig. 10 varies the provisioned adapter width, the cohort size, and the label heterogeneity of the trainer on CIFAR-10. Each variant uses five seeds; the nominal reference column uses ten. Widening the provisioned adapter leaves accuracy flat while network cost rises; the width is a network-facing decision rather than an accuracy control. Cohort size leaves accuracy flat at linearly scaled bytes. Data heterogeneity moves accuracy as Table 5 shows at constant network cost. Per-decision scheduling cost is negligible in all settings: the per-client rank

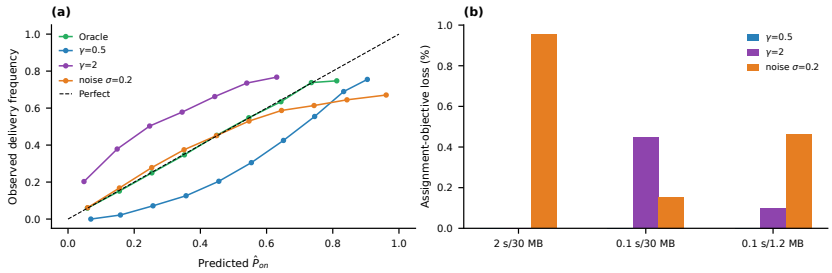


Figure 9: Delivery-predictor calibration study (500 clients, 150 round-instances per cell). The left panel shows reliability at the 0.1 s deadline. With oracle link state the hazard-form predictor is calibrated by construction, while the power-distorted (γ) and noisy variants are measurably miscalibrated. The right panel shows the assignment-objective loss of optimizing against the distorted predictor, evaluated under true probabilities, at most 1% in every cell.

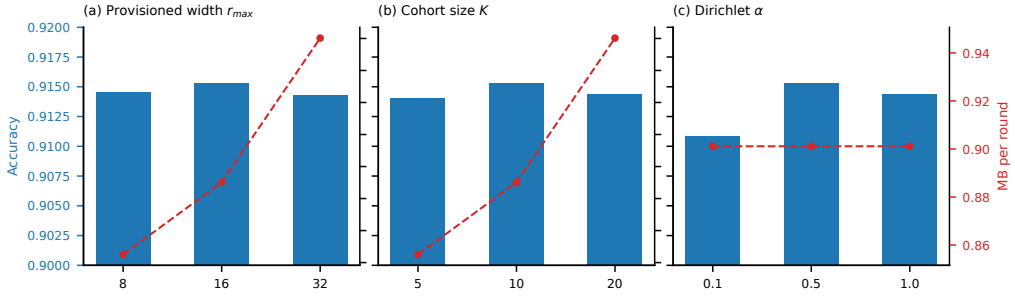


Figure 10: Sensitivity of the trainer to provisioned adapter width, cohort size, and label heterogeneity on CIFAR-10 with FedRAS (five seeds per variant; the nominal reference column uses ten seeds). Accuracy is flat in $r_{\max}$, cohort size, and α across the tested ranges; their effect is on bytes and delivered updates (red, right axis).

rule costs sub-millisecond per decision, orders of magnitude below the full grid-scheduling DP of Section 6.3.2.

SAGIN link profile. Grouping the 20 clients into ground, aerial, and satellite classes with distinct rate and mobility laws reproduces the aggregate parity at the nominal deadline (accuracy 0.9141) while exposing the expected per-class structure: timely delivery is 0.71 for ground, 0.61 for aerial, and 0.49 for satellite clients. At this deadline the scheduler holds rank 16 across all classes, so the class gap reflects the link laws alone rather than rank allocation. This profile is a parameterized link model, not a measured trace; its role is to show that the scheduler responds sensibly to client-class heterogeneity.

Cross-tier summary. Taken together, the two evaluation tiers give a consistent picture. Rank choice does not measurably change accuracy for the frozen backbone at the 40-round horizon, and every accuracy comparison against fixed rank 16 passes the pre-registered TOST equivalence test at the ± 0.5 percentage-point margin; an offline control without delivery modeling trains close to the backbone level, separating learning capacity from delivery feasibility. The methods instead separate on the network side: FedRAS holds high ranks on healthy links and downshifts under pressure, full-parameter updates collapse once deadlines bind at real payload sizes, and the exact scheduler pays through admission over the candidate pool rather than in-cohort rank allocation (Proposition 2). These tests rest on ten-seed replications of the headline trainer regimes; they support the stated network-side comparisons and the accuracy equivalence, and they do not establish accuracy dominance. Section 7 interprets these findings, states their scope conditions, and translates them into deployment guidance.

7. Discussion and limitations

7.1. Interpretation and deployment considerations

Why the gains are network-side. The trainer demonstrates parity and equivalence, not rank-dependent accuracy gains. With a strong frozen backbone and 40 adaptation rounds, transmitted rank does not measurably change test accuracy, because the accuracy is carried by the pretrained features while the scheduler shapes which updates arrive on time and at what byte cost. Claims that low rank limits adaptation quality would require longer horizons, weaker backbones, or distribution-shifted clients.

When FedRAS does not help. Three settings bound the method's value. First, when links are healthy and the budget accommodates every candidate at the provisioned width, FedRAS reduces exactly to fixed rank 16 (Proposition 2): the scheduling layer adds coordination cost and nothing else. FedRAS is therefore worth its coordination cost when deadlines are tight relative to real payloads or when the byte budget binds; outside those regimes, fixed rank 16 is the identical and simpler choice. Second, under extreme label heterogeneity, higher ranks lose accuracy relative to low ranks through capacity-amplified client drift, and FedRAS follows the high-rank trajectory and inherits that loss; conditioning the capacity term $G(r)$ on measured heterogeneity is left as future work. Third, under tight deadlines

the weakest client class still delivers least, because downshifting protects delivery but cannot create link capacity.

Deployment recipe. The results translate into three planning rules for a practitioner. Calibrate the deadline ladder from the real payload of the widest provisioned rank, so that the nominal deadline leaves rank $r_{\max}$ near-constraint-free while at least one stress deadline drives its timely delivery below one half. Size the byte budget at ten times the grid cost of rank $r_{\max}$, which forces the budget to bind only through downshifting or skipping. Finally, by Proposition 2, use the per-client argmax rule when the budget accommodates every candidate at rank $r_{\max}$ and invoke the full dynamic program only when the pool is heterogeneous enough that admission control matters.

7.2. Scope and limitations

Scope of claims. The results describe network-side gains in the evaluated frozen-backbone setting; they must not be read as universal accuracy gains. The simulator capacity model is a scheduling abstraction, and its accuracy column is a bounded scheduling proxy rather than a measured dataset accuracy.

Backbone pretraining. The centralized pretraining stage is a documented premise inherited from parameter-efficient FL practice; the federated phase adapts but does not train the backbone. Where no server-side corpus exists, self-supervised or public-data pretraining would be needed, and the parity result should be re-verified.

Estimator assumptions. The hazard-form delivery model (3) assumes the closed-form exponential realization, and the experiments supply generated link states as oracle estimates; training and processing times are included in the conceptual delivery model (1) but are not separately measured. Production deployments should calibrate P_{on} per client from observed outcomes, for example with isotonic or Platt scaling monitored by a Brier score, and the scheduler treats the predictor as a plug-in. Calibration on measured wireless traces remains open.

Myopia. The analysis is deliberately per-round (Section 5); a horizon-aware policy that shifts admissions across rounds as budgets carry over and mobility correlates is a natural extension.

Security. The adversary and trust assumptions are stated in Section 3.4. This work proposes no protection mechanism and makes no privacy claim;

differential-privacy accounting, secure aggregation, and Byzantine robustness compose orthogonally with rank scheduling [38, 39].

Generality. The trainer validates adapters on convolutional and linear layers of a CNN at $r_{\max}$=16 with 20 clients, and the simulator extends the population to 1000, both under synthetic link distributions. Extension to transformer backbones, measured rather than synthetic links, and larger rank sets may change the payload slope, capacity curve, and empirical conclusions. The formulation can be tested in those settings. The study does not measure energy, system overhead beyond scheduler runtime, or client fairness and therefore makes no claim about those properties.

8. Conclusion

This paper reframed Federated LoRA over mobile edge networks as a deadline-aware client–rank scheduling problem in which the LoRA rank is a network-visible resource accounted at its real serialized size. We derived a rank-conditioned delivery model, formulated the per-round assignment as a multiple-choice knapsack under budget and participation caps, solved the grid-discretized assignment with a pseudo-polynomial dynamic program, and stabilized heterogeneous-rank aggregation with frozen-factor rank-masked averaging in which only the trainable factor is ever transmitted.

Experiments with a real federated LoRA trainer and a 500-client scheduler simulation, with deadlines calibrated to real payloads, show that rank selection preserves backbone accuracy up to a pre-registered equivalence margin while reshaping the network side of the exchange: under ten-seed deadline stress, FedRAS delivers 22% more timely updates and 23% fewer bytes than fixed rank 16, and the exact scheduler earns its cost through admission over heterogeneous candidate pools rather than through in-cohort rank allocation. The claims are conditional on the frozen-backbone setting and synthetic link models: rank scheduling adds value when deadlines bind relative to real payloads or when the byte budget binds, and reduces to fixed-rank operation otherwise. Future work includes horizon-aware stochastic scheduling, calibrated per-client delivery predictors on measured traces, protection mechanisms composed with rank scheduling, and validation on transformer backbones.

Declaration of competing interest

The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.

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Wenyu Ma: Methodology, Software, Validation, Investigation, Writing – original draft. **Tao Hu:** Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Supervision, Writing – review and editing. **Xinlei Liu:** Data curation, Investigation, Visualization. All authors approved the submitted version and accept responsibility for the work.

Data availability

The reproducibility package accompanying this submission contains the complete source code (trainer, simulator, solver, and analysis scripts), per-run configuration files, per-seed result tables, and the raw training logs supporting every table and figure in this study; a permanent repository DOI will be supplied at publication.

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